

Teaching Statement
Hema Shah
Economics PhD Candidate, Duke University

I regard teaching economics tools to students from a variety of educational disciplines and backgrounds as a core component of my scholarship and impact. I bring experience teaching courses at both the undergraduate and graduate level within a large public and a selective private university. I have served as a teaching assistant for the first year PhD sequence in econometrics at Duke and for undergraduate courses in statistics and applied microeconomics at the University of Virginia, and I have bolstered my experience as a teaching assistant with numerous mentorship roles. My experience as a teaching assistant and mentor has shaped my teaching philosophy grounded in compassionate mentorship and practical applications of economics as a cross-disciplinary toolkit. I am qualified to teach both undergraduate and graduate coursework in econometrics, labor economics, applied microeconomics, research methods, and microeconomic theory. I am particularly excited about developing and teaching applied empirical methods courses, such as a capstone or thesis writing course, and economics of education courses, such as a “cradle to career” course covering topics from early childhood through higher education.

Compassionate Mentorship

As a teaching assistant for the first year PhD econometrics sequence at Duke, I prioritized compassionate mentorship of first year PhD students, master’s students, and advanced undergraduates. When leading TA sessions, I prepared detailed step-by-step explanations of problem sets and was open about the concepts I struggled with when completing the problem sets myself as a first year PhD student. I offered virtual and in-person office hours and made myself available for individual appointments with struggling students. I found that students were eager to ask questions about course material and seek advice about the transition to PhD level coursework when given a supportive environment in which to express their concerns. In turn, students who asked questions and sought advice openly were better able to tackle challenging problems independently on future exams. My experience serving as a peer mentor to prospective economics PhD students from across the globe, through the Duke Economics Graduate Mentorship Program, and to first year Duke economics PhD students, through the Duke Economics Graduate Student Council, has deepened my commitment to compassionate mentorship.

Practical Applications

My focus on compassionate mentorship is complemented by a commitment to practical applications of economic tools across disciplinary boundaries. As a fellow of the Program for Advanced Research in Social Science (PARISS), I worked as a consultant in the Duke University Social Science Research Institute. My role was to assist students from various education levels and disciplines with independent research in the social sciences. I assisted researchers ranging from undergraduate students in political science, economics, and public policy to postdoctoral researchers in the Duke University School of Medicine with questions at different stages of the research process, including dataset identification, statistical analysis, programming, and data visualization. This experience challenged me to avoid economics-specific analytical norms and jargon and seek cross-disciplinary commonalities when working through research problems. I explained challenging statistical concepts by linking the concepts directly to students’ research areas of interest. I found that this approach allowed students with little formal statistics training to master difficult concepts quickly and apply them to the research questions they cared most deeply about. My experience as a PARISS fellow, along with my

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work on the interdisciplinary Baby's First Years research study, has solidified my goal of equipping students across disciplines to apply economics tools to important research questions.

I am eager to apply my skills to foster student learning and mentor young researchers in my next position. Ultimately, my goal as an educator is to inspire students to see economics not only as a set of analytical tools but as a framework for engaging with the most pressing challenges in their fields and communities.

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Excellent

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 30%

**How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during
his or her office hours?**

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Excellent

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 70%

How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during his or her office hours? 2

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Excellent

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 80%

How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during his or her office hours? 0

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

TA sessions were great, and they really helped in covering the material and problem sets. I felt confident that if I didn't understand something on the pset, the solutions sheet + TA sessions would answer my question

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Good

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 20%

How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during his or her office hours? once

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

I didn't go to many of the TA sessions, but I did go to a few. Hema was always professional and explained the HW intuitively. I didn't go to many of the sessions because I had already done the HWs and could look at the solutions or confer with other students in my program. I think it would have been more helpful for Hema to give examples that complemented the lectures. She could also be available for questions about the HWs.

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

I found that going over the HW solutions was a poor use of discussion time, since all the students had spent time going over the HWs and could look at the solutions which contain a lot of detail. I think the sessions could have been vastly improved if Hema went over examples that complemented the lectures. Masten teaches quite quickly and often doesn't go over examples since he has so much material to cover. The TA sessions could be a way to bridge the gap.

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Excellent

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 100%

How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during his or her office hours? 3

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

Hema is the best: she did not only offer clear delivery about the course material, but also provided nice suggestions on how should we select and perform well for the economics phd courses.

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

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Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Good

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 20%

**How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during
his or her office hours?** 3

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Excellent

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 100%

How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during his or her office hours? Many

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

Very good TA and always willing to help students

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

Hold office hours at later time

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Good

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 50%

How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during his or her office hours? 10

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

Hema's advice/suggestions have been helpful whenever I've asked her a specific question about a homework or the course and studying in general. She is also very understanding and seems to care about our first-year experience and stresses.

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Excellent

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 10%

How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during his or her office hours? 2

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

Very helpful and responsive.

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Excellent

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 0%

**How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during
his or her office hours?**

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Excellent

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 30%

**How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during
his or her office hours?** 1

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

Hema answered my questions over email often and it was very helpful.

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

Considering all relevant factors, how would you rate your teaching / assistant? Excellent

What percent of the section meetings have you attended this / semester? 100%

How many times have you consulted with your teaching assistant / during his or her office hours? 4

In the space below, indicate your opinion about your teaching assistant's contribution to your learning in this course. Cover everything you consider relevant: section meetings, office hours, grading, consultations, etc. (The results of this question will be available to the Course Professor, the Directors of Undergraduate and Graduate Studies, and the Teaching Assistant.)

thank Hema for her help in the additional practicing questions and the course materials, but I do believe the TA sessions should be held either before the first class of the week or after the last class of the week.

In the space below, indicate specific ways you feel the Teaching Assistant could improve his/her effectiveness in this course. Be constructive. (The results of this question will be available ONLY to the Teaching Assistant.)

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